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A: Sustainability is a business imperative, not something that is “nice to have.” It’s embedded in Nestlé’s DNA. We have a sustainability steering committee that I chair, overseeing projects in these four areas. These initiatives are business-driven, monitored, KPI-focused, and transparently reported.

Q: Your BRSR report for FY24 was majorly inclined towards renewable energy and recycling. What new strategic sectors have you tapped in FY25?

A: One of the things we would look at tapping, and which ties in with the globally enlisted large initiatives, is to start collaborating with other like-minded companies on sustainability projects. It is a little bit like CSR (corporate social responsibility) initiatives. **If you partner with companies, you are able to make a much bigger impact on either rural water or education or sanitation. In the same manner, if you are able to come together as companies, there is a bigger play that can be had on sustainability as well.**

Q: Have you tied up with early-stage start-ups or companies that are deep down in sustainability along with technology?

A: We have had a few initial initiatives, especially in the packaging area. Some of it is very nascent at this stage. For example, in the use of seaweed as a sustainable packaging source, there was start-up that we worked with. Similarly, there are projects we are working on in the use of wood and other such waste in designing sustainable packaging material.

Q: Where do you see Nestlé India in the next five years regarding responsible sourcing and climate commitments?

A: Sustainability is not a one-time effort; it’s a marathon. We believe in consistent discipline, focus and hard work. The four key initiatives I mentioned earlier will remain central to our efforts. We aim to be the best-in-class in sustainability, but never lose sight of affordability and relevance for consumers.

Ultimately, our goal is to offer products that are relevant, sustainable, affordable and provide excellent value. This means balancing cost, sustainability, pricing and value—an equation that evolves but always strengthens our connection with consumers.

Q: How do you strike a balance between sustainability and affordability of products?

“Be it coffee, milk, spices or oils, 55–60% of our materials are sustainably sourced, with coffee nearing 100%”

A: I think this is where the equation comes between the sustainability cost and how much of it are we able to mitigate through either technology, recipes or optimisation of usage. In some categories, this can be managed quite effectively and efficiently. In some others, there are short-term impacts and, therefore, it may not be the most optimal in certain cases.

But in most of the portfolio, we try and balance out sustainability costs with raw material inflation through the possibility of pricing, and then to look at the net equation after that to see what is it that we can afford from a business point of view. **BT**

@tweettokarishma